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Business.Technology

Web site spotlight

Black History Month celebration takes off

By Dave Peyton
Tribune Media Services

Carter G. Woodson would be amazed.

Negro History Week, which he founded in 1926, has become Black History Month. And the news of black history and its impact has spread around the world via the World Wide Web.

For anyone with a computer and access to the Web, there's no excuse for not knowing the contributions that African-Americans have made to world history. In fact, some of the best history sites on the Web are black history sites.

Most of these sites are free and are part of larger, more comprehensive sites. While many of them were created as study sites for students, they provide important information for anyone interested in learning about the contributions that African-Americans have made to the American experience.

The best site has been around since 1997, when it received immediate critical acclaim. It's the Encyclopedia Britannica Guide to Black History (http://blackhistory.eb.com).

The Web site examines five centuries of black history through five distinct time periods. It begins in the 16th Century with the earliest slave revolts in the New World, and takes us through the civil rights movement of the 1960s up to the present. Each era is subdivided by topic/profession and includes biographies and photographs of notable people, as well as descriptions and documents of historic events.

Encyclopedia Britannica has continued to update and refine this site since its inception. Recently added is a timeline that traces the contributions of African-Americans in politics, industry, the arts, religion, sports and education.

This site offers 600 articles with film clips and audio recordings, as well as hundreds of photographs and other images.

For teachers, there's a study guide for students that's organized around six classroom activities, each with its own teacher recommendations, technical tips and scholastic bibliographies.

Infoplease.com has created a special page for Black History Month at www.infoplease.com/spot/bhm1.html. This site offers special articles on important aspects of black history, as well as various timelines.

Special features include articles about Negro League baseball, African-American literature and black scientists and inventors. Students will find quizzes about civil rights leaders, black athletes and African-American artists, writers, actors and musicians.

Exploring your own family history is a special Black History Month feature of the Learning Network's Family Education division.

To get to the site, first go to www.familyeducation.com, then click on the "Celebrate Black History" headline in the middle of the page.

This site aids parents who are helping their children search for family roots. Other features on the site offer quizzes and a guide to learning what Black History Month is all about. Tips for parents include articles about how to raise children free of prejudice, and how to talk to kids about racism.

Black Facts Online (www.blackfacts.com) is a search page that lets you look up Black History information by specific date or keywords.

The Web site is a service of Inner-City Software.



Encyclopedia Britannica's Guide to Black History is one of the best.

The Super-ad Bowl
http://superbowl.adcritic.com

Can't get enough of those Super Bowl commercials? Well, now you have a chance to see them on the Internet. AdCritic offers the crop of commercials from Super Bowl XXXV, as well as commercials from past Super Bowls. It's best to have QuickTime to see the commercials, but Microsoft's Windows Media Player will do in a pinch.

Fighting cancer pain
www.cancer-pain.org

The Association of Online Cancer Resources offers a site about cancer pain and its treatment. Studies have shown that cancer pain remains underreported and undertreated. This site offers information to assist in pain-management decisions by offering the latest developments in treatment to cancer patients, caregivers and medical professionals.

E-mail tribtech@tribune.com.

Life in cyberspace

Cat-lovers see little humor in satirical pet bonsai site

By Joe Salkowski
Tribune Media Services

Have you ever wanted a cat but worried that they're just too darned cuddly?

They sure are graceful, and their little round faces are cute as the dickens. But wouldn't they be even more appealing if they were shaped like a cube?

Such is the twisted dream behind bonsaikitten.com, a popular Web site that claims to have revived the lost art of kitten modification.

It says that with just a jar, a few household tools and the instructions listed on the site, you can mold a standard shelter-grade tabby into any number of aesthetically pleasing shapes.

It's a joke, of course—a straight-faced spoof designed to prey on gullible cat lovers. But there are plenty of people who aren't laughing, including a few wayward agents from the FBI.

The site's principal creators, a pair of grad students at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, say they've been targeted by a grand jury subpoena demanding information about bonsaikitten.com on behalf of the Federal Bureau of Investigation.

The Massachusetts Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals has launched its own investigation into the site. And the Humane Society of the United States has pitched a virtual fit, lobbying service providers to pull bonsaikitten.com off the Web and posting an alert that complains the site is among "the rising number of Web sites that promote, glamorize or trivialize cruelty to animals."

This all comes on top of predictable outrage from cat lovers themselves, who seem to suffer from some sort of debilitating lack of humor caused by overexposure to kitty litter. Bonsaikitten.com has been targeted by tens of thousands of angry e-mail messages.

"I originally expected far more people to understand the satire [in-mediately]," said one of the site's creators, who goes by the pseudonym Dr. Michael Wong Chang. "From our incoming mail, it seems far fewer than 1 percent of respondents understand."

It's hard to see how they missed the joke. The site's front page claims the art of cramming kittens into containers to permanently alter the shape of their bodies was inspired by the bonsai tree.

"Just as a topiary gardener produces bushes that take the forms of animals or any other thing, you no longer need be satisfied with a housepet having the same mundane shape as all other members of its species," it says.

Indeed, the site talks of kittens shaped like teapots, parallelograms, stars, Nutella jars and other such nonsense. There aren't any pictures of such creatures, of course—hint, hint, kitty lovers.

Make no mistake: Animal abuse is serious business. But this Web site isn't, and anyone who actually visits it—federal agents included—should realize it's meant in jest.

"A vast proportion of viewers (or people who refuse to even look at the site before condemning it, as the case may be) refuse to cease being offended even when the message of the site is explained to them in detail," Dr. Chang said in an e-mail interview.

After reading Dr. Chang's explanation, I'm not sure I really get it, either.

But bonsaikitten.com makes me laugh, which probably reveals that I'm a dog person. It also reminds me of one of the Internet's principal benefits: bringing all sorts of people together, whether they like it or not.

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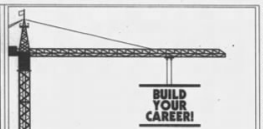
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Heat

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

seeing more interest in hyperthermia," said Harley Griffith, a BSD sales executive. "We're really excited about the prospect of new studies. "Fifteen years ago there were two big studies done in the United States, and neither had very impressive results. That was pretty much the end of hyperthermia here. But the European researchers got into it later after some of the bugs were worked out, and they've gotten better results."

Hyperthermia has suffered from inherent difficulties of heating tumors within the body, but also from a troublesome lack of precision in agreeing to what constitutes therapeutic hyperthermia, he said.

"The problem is that somebody could take a hot water bottle, put it against a patient and say that's hyperthermia," said Griffith. "We suffered from a lack of standards, and that made insurance carriers very reluctant to reimburse for hyperthermia."

Another problem, said Griffith, is that among various medical specialties, there is no natural constituency to push a hospital administrator to spend half a million dollars on hyperthermia equipment.

If large studies could show a clear benefit to the therapy, problems of insurance reimbursement and a lack of champions among medical specialties likely would be overcome, he said.

Dr. Ellen Jones, an assistant professor of radiation oncology at Duke University, said the reason early studies showed little benefit from hyperthermia may have been that the equipment didn't heat large tumors sufficiently to produce an effect.

"While hyperthermia is quite promising, it is technically not as straightforward as other approaches," said Jones, who has been using the technology at Duke for more than a decade. "Hyperthermia can be very labor-intensive to use."

Although it is possible to deliver heat to tumors inside the body by using microwaves, measuring heat within a tumor is difficult, Jones said. The most direct approach is to insert probes in the tumor to take its temperature, but that is an invasive procedure.

A newer approach still under study is to use magnetic resonance imaging to monitor tumor temperature noninvasively, and Duke researchers are looking at the feasibility of doing that, Jones said.

Another center that has continued to use hyperthermia is the Centennial Medical Center in Nashville, where Dr. Steven Stroup, director of radiation oncology, has been using heat to treat patients with rectal cancer.

The patients receive hyperthermia to enhance the tumor-killing powers of radiation and chemotherapy, Stroup said. They are then treated with surgery, but a less radical surgery than is traditional—full removal of the colon is not required.

If the results prove as successful as hoped, the aim is eventually to forgo any surgery, Stroup said.

Initial indications are that hyperthermia can enhance the tumor-fighting power of radiation and chemotherapy twofold, he said.

"We've been doing this about four years now and are very pleased with the results," said Stroup.

Centennial is also studying use of MRI to monitor tumor heating, but has been put off by the expense, Stroup said. Instead, Stroup's team has done extensive computer modeling to devise a way to estimate accurately the temperatures within a tumor based upon that amount of energy being directed at it.

By testing the computer model in phantoms constructed to mimic the human body's reaction to microwave energy, Stroup said that it may be possible to reduce the amount of invasive probing necessary to monitor tumor temperatures.

"Hyperthermia works," said Stroup. "But it's very labor-intensive, and it's as much art as science. I think there will be a resurgence in it as people look for new ways to enhance their treatments."

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